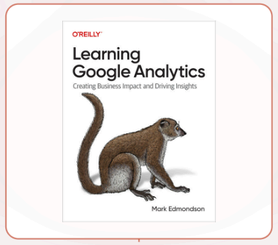


Mark Edmondson

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THE SAME JOURNEY, ONE LAYER UP EACH TIME

SEO · ANALYTICS · DATA SCIENCE · CLOUD · AI

Death by PowerPoint

coined by Angela R. Garber · **Small Business Computing, 2001**

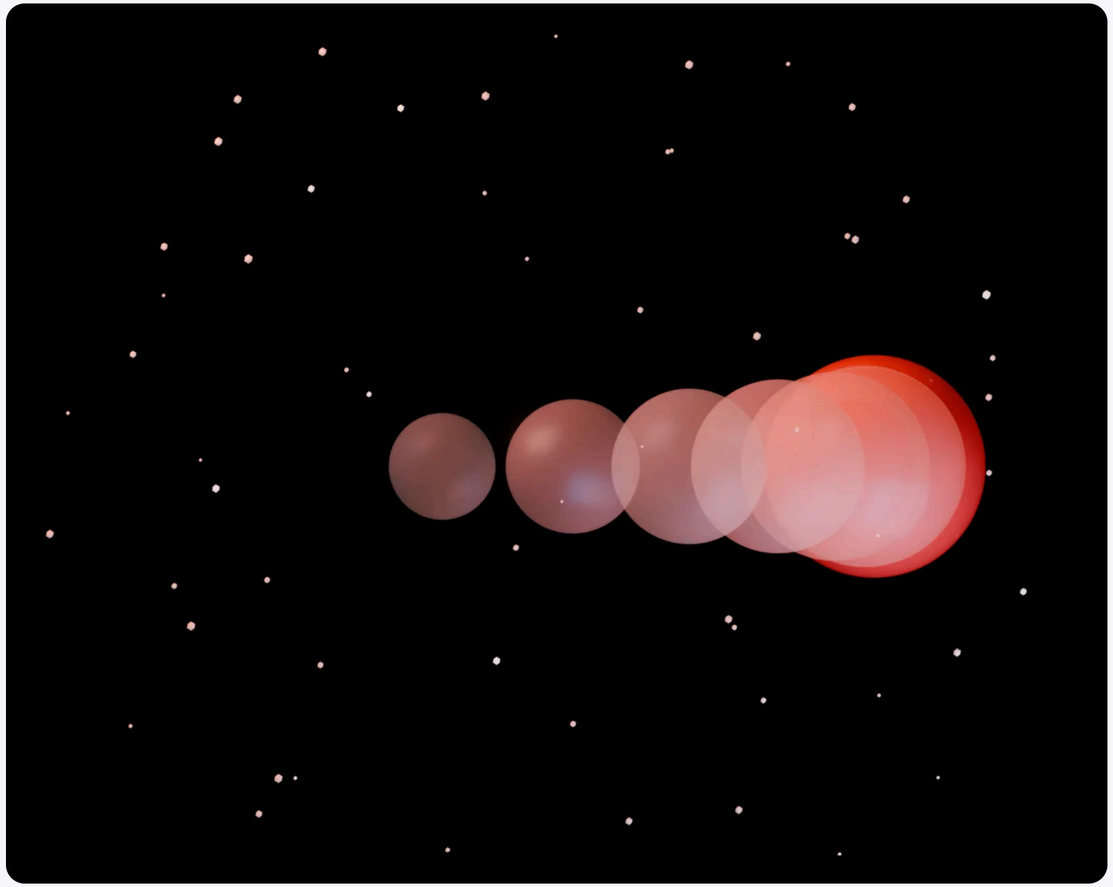
twenty-five years of advice for the presenter

Fewer bullets. Bigger type. No clip art. Tell a story. All good advice, all for the presenter. **None of it was for the tool.** Yet the tool decided what a slide is: a fixed box you fill by dragging smaller boxes.

</> LOOK CLOSER

This is not a slide. It’s a web page.

sunholo.com/presentations/**death-by-powerpoint/**



This is one HTML file, the format of every web page. Layout, style and code are all in it. Nothing to build, no licence. The Blender 3D scene (a GLB file) plays in your browser, and you can turn it. **I didn’t write this page.** An AI agent did, following rules I wrote in English. Ask to see the code in the Q&A.

⇄ THE SHIFT

What made PowerPoint sensible is gone

1987 – 2024

A person places every box by hand

So you give them a blank page and some boxes. For that job, PowerPoint is a *good design*. Every complaint about it comes from this.

NOW

An AI can write the code

Now the thing making your deck writes code well. So why ask it for a locked PowerPoint file?

This slide is my whole argument. I am not saying PowerPoint is bad. For thirty-seven years it was a sensible answer to a real limit. The limit changed. The tool didn’t.

THESIS

Generate the medium, not the ~~file format~~.

Your audience never gets a `.pptx`. They get a screen, and later a PDF and a broken link. That screen is the medium: what people actually see. Make it directly, and nothing is lost in a conversion. **The rest of these 45 minutes builds on this idea.**

THE ROUND TRIP

Count the conversions

Idea	.pptx	Their projector	Export to PDF	Screenshot	Someone’s phone
—	boxed into a rectangle	wrong fonts	animation is lost	links die	unreadable

Five conversions sit between your idea and the person. Each one loses something. You chose none of them. They are the price of making a **file format** your output. The embedded video never arrives. It never has.

ASK FOR WHAT IT'S GOOD AT

Same slide title, two formats

.PPTX — A ZIP OF XML

```
<p:sp>
  <p:nvSpPr>
    <p:cNvPr id="2" name="Title 1"/>
  </p:nvSpPr>
  <p:spPr><a:xfrm>
    <a:off x="838200" y="365125"/>
    <a:ext cx="10515600" cy="1325563"/>
  </a:xfrm></p:spPr>
  <p:txBody><a:p><a:r>
    <a:t>Generate the medium</a:t>
  </a:r></a:p></p:txBody>
</p:sp>
```

Positions in English Metric Units. The model can't open it to check.

</> HTML — THE PAGE ITSELF

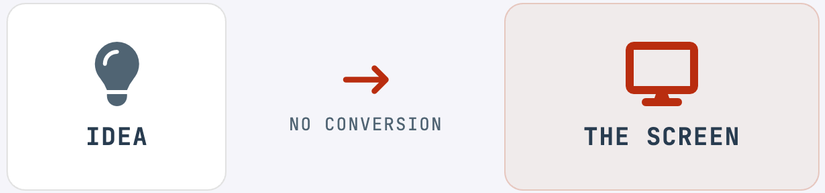
```
<h1 class="slide-title">
  Generate the medium
</h1>
```

Shows up at once. You can see it, so you can tell the agent it's wrong.

You **can** make `.pptx` files. The tools exist. But the model can't open the file and check its own work. HTML and CSS are the code behind web pages. The model has seen far more of them than almost anything else. **You don't have to write it. You only read enough to say "that's wrong."**

THE REAL OUTPUT

One arrow



Your audience ends up looking at a page on a screen. Make that page directly. Then nothing sits in between to lose anything. **Live data stays live. Links stay links. The whole deck arrives as one file.**

⚖ THE HONEST LIST

What you gain, what you give up

+ GAINED

- ✓ No licence, no “created in a newer version”
- ✓ No swapped fonts — the page brings its own
- ✓ Opens on anything with a browser
- ✓ Shared as a link, tracked in git
- ✓ The slide can *run things*

— GIVEN UP

- ⚠ Your company template — your brand, yes (section 3). The .pptx master file, no.
- ⚠ A file a colleague can edit in PowerPoint — they edit the page instead
- ⚠ Animation by menu — you describe it instead
- ⚠ Needs a browser, and internet for the live parts — a PDF covers rooms with no wifi

Most of the right-hand column has an answer. I’ll show you the PDF export later. **If your organisation insists on the template file, you may lose that fight.** Take the design system from the next section anyway. That is the part that carries your brand.

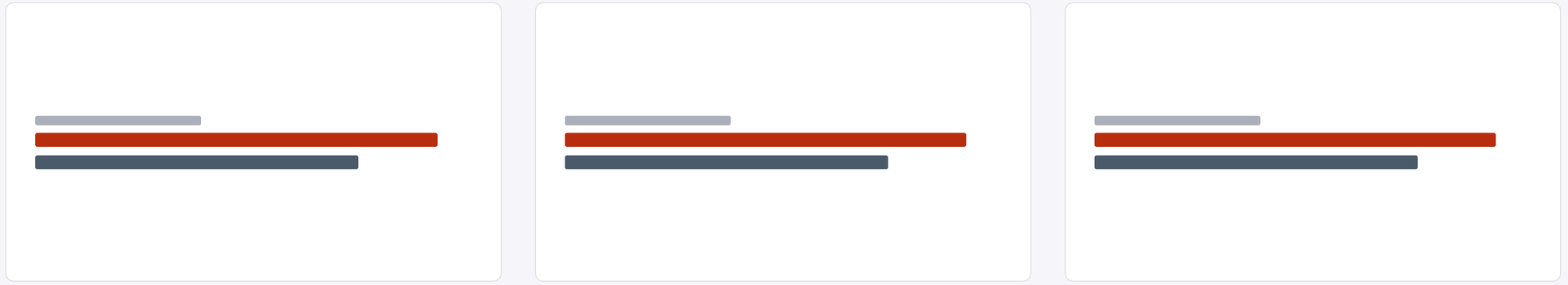
THE REAL PROBLEM

Ask three times, get three decks

✕ SAME PROMPT, NO DESIGN SYSTEM



✓ SAME PROMPT, USING THE SLIDES SKILL



A deck is not eleven separate pictures. It is **one thing, seen eleven times**. If every slide looks a bit different, an AI-built deck feels cheap. With no guidance, the model makes the average slide: a colour gradient, three boxes, a stock icon. It looks fine. **Fine is the problem.**

AGENT SKILLS

A skill is a folder of know-how

You ask

“Make me a slide about our Q3 results.”

Your AI agent

“That’s a slides job. I’ll open the slides skill.”

presentation-slides/

- `SKILL.md` — when to use it, and the steps
- `design-system.md` — our look, in plain words
- `boilerplate.md` — a deck that already works
- `lint-slides.mjs` — automatic checks

Write it once. **Every request after that uses it.**

A skill is a folder of instructions for your AI agent. The first lines say what it is for. When your request matches, the agent opens the folder and follows it. The instructions are plain English, so you don’t need to code to write one. We use Claude Code; the folder format is an open standard that other coding agents read too.

INSIDE THE SKILL

Three things keep every slide the same

Rules in words

FOR TASTE

“Orange is for emphasis. Never overused.”

The AI uses judgement

Templates

FOR STRUCTURE

“Start from a deck that already works.”

Never a blank page

Automatic checks

FOR HARD RULES

“Text falls off the slide? Fail.”

Same answer every time

Each part does a different job. Words guide the AI where taste matters. A template means it never starts from scratch. Checks catch the mistakes that must never reach the screen. You need all three.

1 · RULES IN WORDS

Write your taste down in plain words

EXCERPT · .CLAUDE/SKILLS/PRESENTATION-SLIDES/SKILL.MD

- **Orange accent** (`#e73c17` dark / `#bd3012` light) for emphasis, **never overused**.
- **Montserrat** for all text, **JetBrains Mono** for code and data.

“Never overused” is not a number. It needs **judgement**, and the AI is good at that.

This is the brand guide you already have. The difference is that this reader actually follows it. **You can write one for your own brand this afternoon.** It works for any AI task, not only slides.

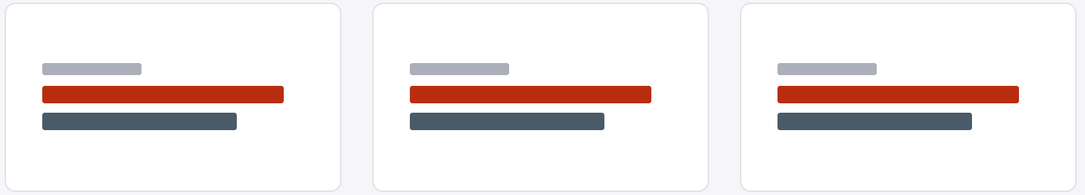
2 · TEMPLATES

Never start from a blank page

The template deck

- the 16:9 slide shape
- dark and light themes
- keyboard and clicker keys
- the presenter view and timer

the AI copies it, then writes only the new content



EVERY NEW TALK

The hard parts are solved once, in the template. The AI copies a deck that already works and changes only the content. That is faster, and it can’t forget the theme switch or the keyboard keys.

3 · AUTOMATIC CHECKS

A check gives the same answer every time

The AI edits a slide → The check runs by itself → “Text is sized to the window, not the slide” → The AI fixes it → Pass

A check is a tiny program. **Same file in, same answer out.** You can’t talk it round.

Written rules get followed most of the time. That is not enough when you only see the mistake on stage. So the simple rules are checked by code, after every edit, with no human in the loop. My example: text sized to the browser window falls off the bottom on a projector. The check catches it every time.

TAKE THIS BIT WITH YOU

Which one do I use?

Can a computer check it with a yes or no?	YES →	**Automatic check**
Is it the same structure every time?	YES →	**Template**
Everything else	→	**Rules in words**

This works for any job you give an AI, not only slides. Reports, emails and contracts all have taste, structure and hard rules. Two mistakes to avoid: don’t turn taste into a strict rule, and don’t trust words alone for a hard rule.

BEFORE I SWITCH WINDOWS

Four things to watch for

01 The prompt is **plain English**. I don’t type any CSS.

02 The agent **reads the design system first**. Then it writes.

03 The linter flags a mistake. The agent **fixes it by itself**.

04 I reload the browser. **That’s the deploy.**
No export. No conversion. No “save as”.

If you remember one of these, make it number three. The rest is convenience. **The agent cannot skip or argue with the check.** That is why I trust this enough to show it on a big screen.

LIVE · BUILDING A SLIDE

Over to the live demo

⌨ THE EXACT PROMPT. COPY IT FROM THE RECORDING

```
Add one slide to the steal-this deck. List the three
files to copy to start: the design system, the linter,
one working deck. Match the deck's design system.
```

Watch: **SKILL.md** → the agent writes HTML → the linter checks it → reload.

This slide stays up while I work in the editor. If the demo breaks, I come back here and say so. Then I go to the next slide. It explains the whole process, even if the demo failed. **Nobody enjoys watching someone fix bugs live.**

THE LOOP

What just happened

ASK
One sentence in English

READ THE RULES
SKILL.md, design system, sizing rules

WRITE
HTML into a real file in git

LINT
Runs by itself after each edit

RELOAD
Published

← lint fails → the agent reads the error → fixes it → retries

Nothing in that loop is only for slides. It is **an agent, written rules, and a check that fails loudly**. Use it for anything your team makes again and again. The slide is now a file in git. You can see what changed, and someone can review it.

BEYOND SLIDE SOFTWARE

Two things a slide couldn't do

EXHIBIT A · NEXT

It can run a real model

A four-stroke engine simulation, running in the slide. Move a slider and the physics answers.

`../assets/otto-engine/index.html`

EXHIBIT B · THEN

It can animate an idea

The development loop, animated. It is the same loop that built the slide you saw ten minutes ago.

`../ai-slaves-human-masters-ida/03-development-loop.html`

Look at the file paths. **Neither of these is in this talk's folder.** The engine comes from AIPLA. The animation comes from my IDA Driving AI talk in May. This deck loads them live, from where they already are.

REUSE

A talk is a list of files

```
const PLAYLIST = [
  { src: '../about-mark/about-mark.html',                          minutes: 1  },
  { src: '00-death-by-powerpoint.html',                            minutes: 4  },
  { src: '01-generate-the-medium.html',                            minutes: 6  },
  { src: '02-teaching-taste.html',                                 minutes: 8  },
  { src: '03-live-build.html',                                     minutes: 12 },
  { src: '04-beyond-slide-software.html',                          minutes: 5  },
  { src: '../ai-slaves-human-masters-ida/03-development-loop.html', minutes: 1  },
  { src: '05-three-audiences.html',                                minutes: 6  },
  { src: '07-steal-this.html',                                     minutes: 2  },
  { src: '../contact-mark/contact-mark.html',                       minutes: 0  },
];
```



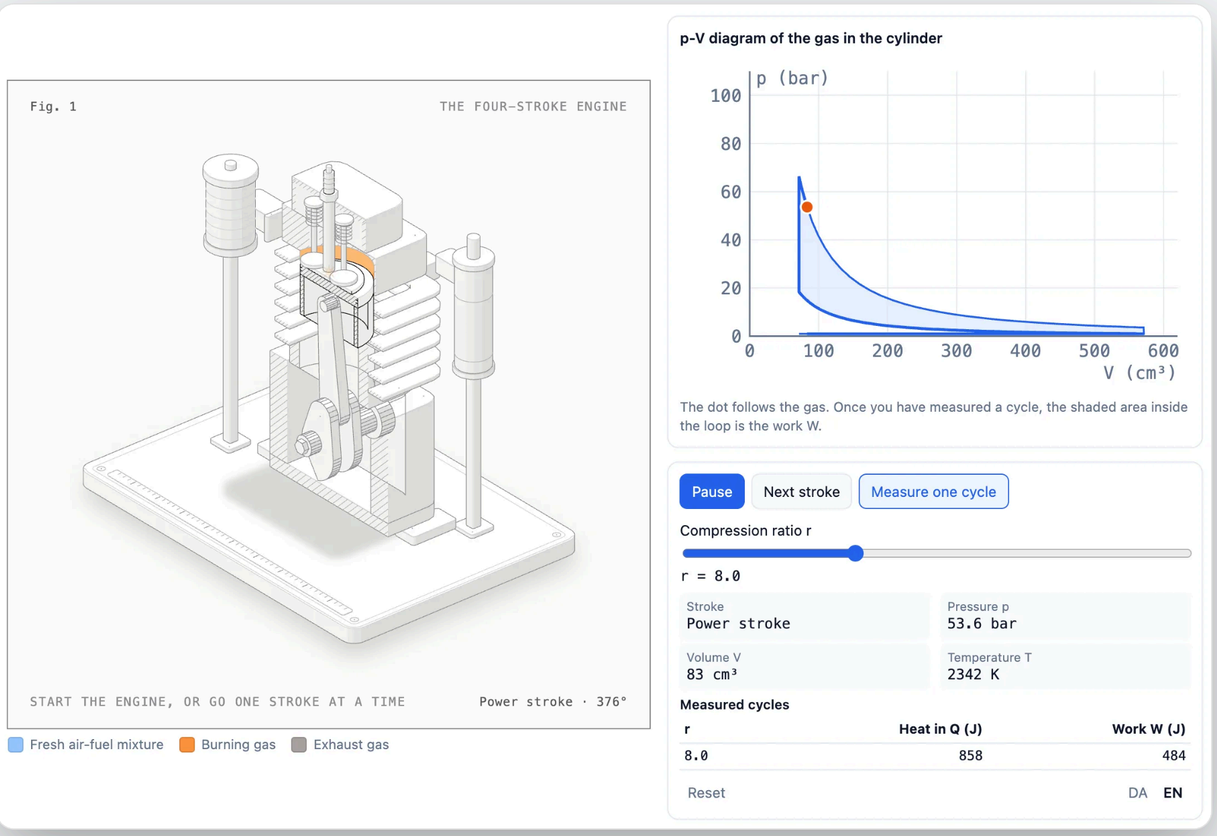
Nothing was copied. Those three entries point to files in other talks' folders. Each file lives in one place. Fix a typo once, and every talk that uses it is fixed. **To reorder a talk, I edit this list.** So I no longer dread the email asking for "the same thing but twenty minutes." **That request now takes about a minute.**

LIVE MODEL

A working engine, inside the slide

Not a picture. **Drag the compression ratio** and the graph redraws.

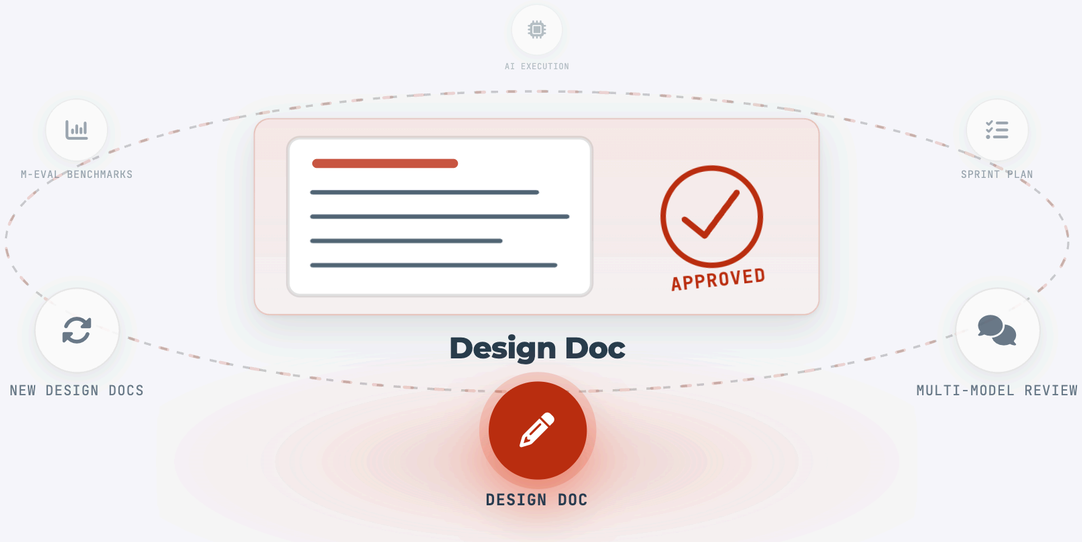
AIPLA · University of Copenhagen
aipla.ku.dk



A teaching tool from AIPLA. An AI agent built it from two documents: a physics brief and written rules for drawing 3D cut-away views. This is the same idea as the design system in section 3: write your taste down in plain words. Here it shapes something that isn't a slide. The deck loads the model only when this slide appears. The PDF gets a still image.

The Development Loop

SIX STAGES · THE BRIEF LOOPS BACK · NOTHING RUNS WITHOUT IT



A human writes the brief. Nothing else runs until it's approved.

ONE DECK, THREE READERS

You are writing for three people

The room, right now

Wants a simple slide while you talk. Six words and a picture. Anything more pulls attention from you.

USUALLY

You get this one right. Most decks are made only for this reader.

Someone opening the link in six weeks

Wants text that explains itself. Nobody is there to talk them through it. They missed the talk.

USUALLY

They get bullet points that only made sense with you talking.

“Can you send me the slides?”

Wants one file to keep, forward and search. Maybe prints two pages.

USUALLY

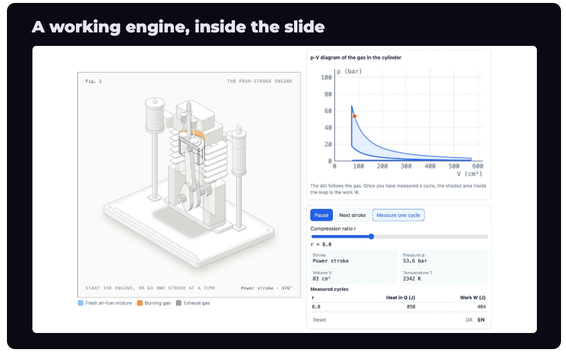
A 40MB attachment that bounces, or a link to a login page.

Usually you pick one of two bad options. One file serves all three badly. Or you keep three files, and two of them go out of date. **The next two slides show one file that serves all three.**

DETAIL

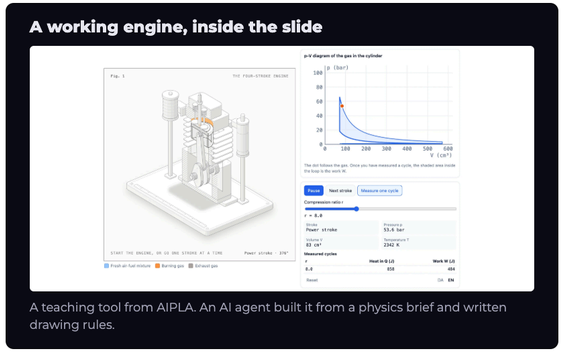
One slide, three readers

The room



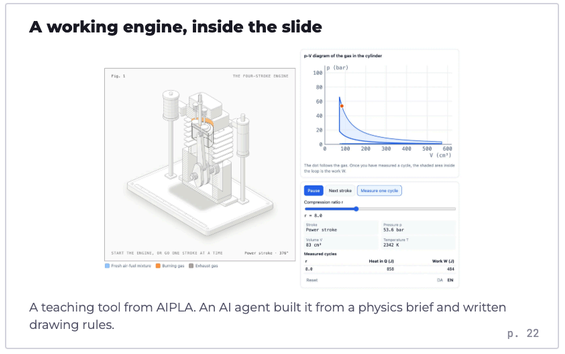
A big picture and a title. **You do the talking.**

The link, later



The same slide, **plus the words you said out loud.**

The PDF



A still picture and the notes. **Easy to keep and forward.**

press `D` now. Every slide in this talk has both.

This is the engine slide from section 5, as each reader gets it. It is one file. The extra words sit in hidden **detail** text. On stage they are hidden. Open the link yourself and they show. The PDF is the same view, saved as pages. **You can read this only because detail is switched on.**

THE PDF

The PDF comes from the live deck

The live deck

the same slide list as this talk

A script photographs it

every slide, fully built

The PDF

plus the notes I said out loud

One command. **The PDF always matches the talk.**

The command is `node export-pdf.mjs death-by-powerpoint --density=guide`. A normal print can't do this, because the slides animate in. So the script opens the real deck in Chrome and takes a picture of each finished slide. **Whoever asked for the slides gets them, plus what I said.**

WHERE IT LIVES

Don’t attach the deck. Put it online.

sunholo.com/presentations/death-by-powerpoint/

It is just plain web files, so hosting costs nothing. It will still open in ten years. No server to update, no database, no login. **This deck will be online before the Q&A ends.** Publishing is one git push, so I can promise that.

TRUST, NOT HOPE

Five questions before you trust it

ASK	THE RULE	IN THIS WORKFLOW
What may it touch?	*“Undeclared capability means denied capability.”*	Only the deck you named. It opens a pull request; **a person merges**.
Can you replay it?	*“If you can’t replay AI, you shouldn’t ship AI.”*	The deck is text in git. Every change can be **diffed and rolled back**.
Can you see what it did?	*“Self-reports are a performance. Action logs are evidence.”*	Judge the **diff, the screenshots and the lint report**, not its explanation.
Were decisions made up front?	*“You pay at design time, at runtime, or in the postmortem.”*	The skill **decides the look once**, before anyone asks for a slide.
Can it say “I don’t know”?	*“Any AI that can’t say ‘I don’t know’ may be lying to you.”*	No invented facts or quotes. **Missing input? It says “BLOCKED”.**

“Can I trust AI?” is the wrong question · six-part series on markedmondson.substack.com

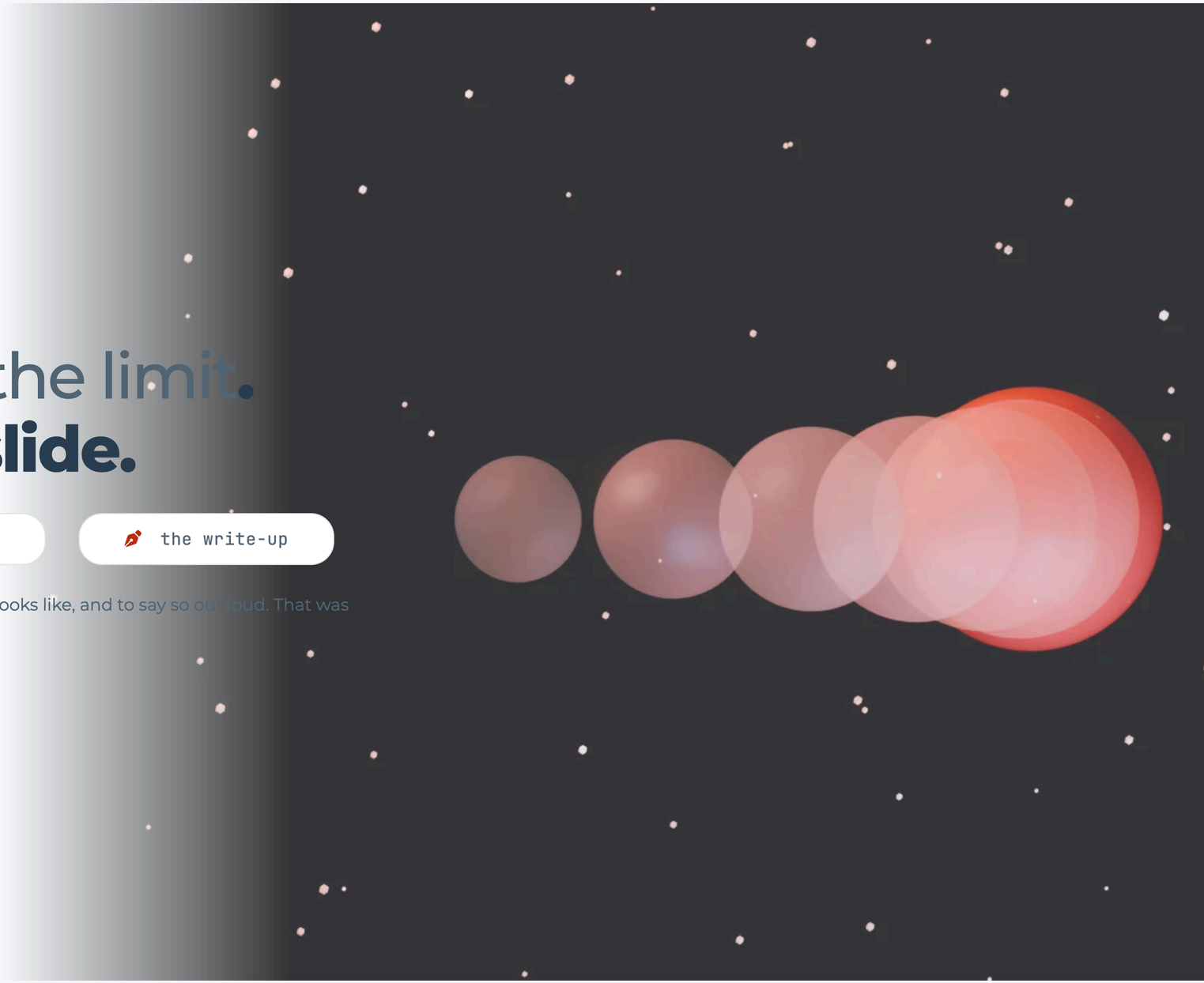
Hallucination is a risk when nobody checks the work. These are the five questions from my series on AI delegation, trust and authority, applied to slides. The rules on the right are written into the repo’s instructions file, which every agent reads first. The checker catches layout, not truth: facts come from the sources you give it, and a person checks the numbers. Trust then moves up one rung at a time, on evidence: slides sit at **proposing**, where the AI does the work and a person approves it.

The tool is no longer the limit.
Ask for more from a slide.

sunholo.com/presentations — every deck, and the template

the write-up

No coding skills required. The AI writes the HTML. Your job is to know what good looks like, and to say so out loud. That was always the job. **Questions?**



THANK YOU

Let's keep talking



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Questions, ideas, or want to keep the conversation going? *Any of the above works.*